

ASEAN ESG Momentum Radar

A second opinion on ESG ratings. It builds its own view of a company from dated, public evidence, compares that view to the rating the market is using, and shows you exactly where the two disagree — along with the reasons it might be wrong. It never tells you to buy or sell.

1 · THE PROBLEM

Almost every sustainable-investing decision starts with an ESG rating — a letter or number from a large data house, saying how good or bad a company is on environmental, social and governance grounds. Three things go wrong with that.

It tells you a level, not a direction — and it arrives late. It says where a company stands, usually from a report filed a year or more ago. It cannot tell you what changed last month, which piece of news holds the score up, or what would move it.

It can go stale with nobody noticing. In the published ASEAN basket we work from, two companies — Malaysia Airports and Intouch

Holdings — were taken private in early 2025 and were still listed as current members. Nothing about the list moved.

Nobody joins the ESG answer to the money answer. "Improving on ESG" and "makes money" are answered by two different tools, so the question an investor actually holds — *is this worth my time, and what would change my mind?* — falls in the gap. A company can improve on ESG and still be a poor business.

And most tools answer by showing you everything — a wall of charts that assumes you already know which question to ask.

The areas we address: sustainable-investing research, trustworthy ESG data, and deciding what deserves a closer look in ASEAN.

2 · WHAT WE BUILT — SIX STEPS, IN PLAIN TERMS

1 · Ask	A few short questions, so the answer fits your situation rather than being a generic screen. Under a minute, on your own machine.
2 · Gather	Up to 27 separate searches per company, along four angles — emissions, governance, financing and controversies — aimed in turn at regulators, exchanges, rating houses and watchdogs, and repeated back across past years. That fourth angle is deliberate: without it, a search quietly becomes a collection of company press releases.
3 · Check	No date or no working source means the fact is dropped. A company announcement cannot pass itself off as a regulator's filing, and a promise about 2050 counts for less than something that already happened.
4 · Score	The AI reads; fixed rules do the scoring. It is never allowed to decide whether something is good or bad, or how much it counts. The same evidence always gives the same answer — nobody, us included, can nudge it.
5 · Bridge	The ESG picture is set beside the company's own financial results, and we say what the two mean together — including the case against our own conclusion.
6 · Record	A fingerprint of everything behind the answer is published and can never be edited, so a verdict can still be checked years later.

3 · NOTHING WE ASK YOU IS DECORATION

Plenty of tools ask questions to feel intelligent, then show everyone the same screen. Our rule is the opposite: **if an answer would only change a line of summary, we do not ask it.** Every input below changes what the tool does, and you can watch the numbers move.

WHAT YOU TELL US	WHAT IT ACTUALLY CHANGES — AND THE QUESTION IT SETTLES
What you are trying to do protect the downside · find upside · satisfy a mandate	Sets which angle we interrogate first and how the answer closes — a risk to watch, an opportunity, or an evidence trail. <i>Settles: what is this analysis for?</i>
How much risk you will carry low · moderate · high	Changes which companies are eligible at all. Low shows only well-documented, profitable, reviewed issuers; high also lets in loss-makers showing early traction, on thinner evidence. <i>Settles: how much unproven upside do you want?</i>
How long you would hold under 2 years · 2–5 · 5–10+	Changes how quickly old news stops counting. On a short hold, anything older than roughly six weeks loses its weight; on a long hold, half a year still counts. Same company, genuinely different verdict. <i>Settles: how long does a fact stay relevant to you?</i>
Whether green financing matters	Companies without a verified green bond are greyed out rather than hidden , so you can still see what you ruled out and why. <i>Settles: does labelled green issuance matter to your mandate?</i>
Screening, or checking one company	Two different paths: sweep the region for disagreements, or interrogate one name in depth. <i>Settles: are you looking for names, or checking one?</i>
Country and industry	Changes the peer group and the industry benchmark, so a bank is measured against banks, never a cement plant. Some industries are carbon-heavy by nature; pretending otherwise is how ESG scores earned their bad name. <i>Settles: compared to what?</i>
How much detail you want	Level 1 is the verdict and one thing to check; level 3 adds every chart, source and date. The evidence stays one click away even at level 1. <i>Settles: how much do you want to check yourself?</i>

4 · WHAT "DISAGREEING WITH THE RATING" ACTUALLY MEANS

We rank each company twice — once on what the evidence says is happening *now*, once on what its published rating says — and report the gap, with a direction. Four plain outcomes: **the rating is behind** (improving faster than it admits), **they agree, flattered by an old score** (well rated, quietly getting worse), and **poorly rated and still slipping**. Because the gap has a direction, a company going backwards can never be dressed up as a find.

What it will never do. It does not say buy, sell or hold, publish a score, or rank companies best-to-worst. Those are regulated claims — and weaker than what we can actually show you: a specific disagreement with a named rating, backed by dated sources, that moves when the evidence moves.

5 · DOES THE COMPANY ALSO MAKE MONEY?

An improving ESG story attached to a failing business is not an investment case. So every ESG verdict is shown beside a read on the company's actual results, taken from two years of verified figures we already hold — nothing estimated, nothing fetched from a paid feed.

Across our 52 companies: **17 strong, 22 adequate, 11 weak, and 2 we cannot tell.** "Cannot tell" is never quietly recorded as "weak" — that would punish a company for a gap in *our* data rather than for its own numbers.

We deliberately do not blend the two into one number. A single combined score sounds authoritative and tells you nothing: you cannot tell whether 7 out of 10 means a good business, a good ESG record, or a mediocre mix of both. Keeping them side by side is what lets you disagree with either half — which is the whole point of the tool.

What comes out is a shortlist of 10 companies: scoring below their own industry's ASEAN peer average, improving on the evidence, and financially sound enough to pass the profitability screen.

6 · WHAT TO LOOK OUT FOR BEFORE INVESTING

Every verdict arrives with its own case against it. Reasons to agree, reasons not to, and the specific warnings that apply to that company: the verdict sits close to a dividing line, some data has not been independently reviewed yet, the evidence is older than the holding period you chose, or too much of it comes from the company's own announcements. **None of it is hidden, dimmed or collapsed.** A case that lists only reasons to agree is marketing.

Two questions we can answer that a rating cannot. **What would change your mind?** — we remove each piece of evidence in turn and tell you which one, if it disappeared, would change the answer. **Have you ever been right before?** — five past cases replayed at their own historical dates, showing our verdict moving while the published rating sat still. **One of the five is a case we got wrong, and we left it in.** A test you can only pass is not a test.

7 · CAN YOU TRUST THE EVIDENCE?

Where facts come from	Public company filings, regulator notices, stock-exchange announcements and news, plus a live rating from a major provider and an industry-wide emissions benchmark that anyone can re-download free in about ten seconds. We read documents — we do not have sensors on smokestacks, and we say so rather than implying otherwise.
How they are checked	No date, no source, no entry. The kind of source is decided by us, not claimed by the publisher. A company's own announcement is capped so it can never count as much as an independent filing — the reason so many ESG tools have been embarrassed by a firm that looked excellent right up until it did not.
The receipt	After each run we publish one small fingerprint of everything that went into it. It cannot be overwritten — a second attempt is rejected outright. It holds no company names or scores, and nothing can be read back out of it.

What that receipt does and does not prove. It does not make a claim true — nothing published to a blockchain can do that, and anyone who says otherwise is selling something. What it proves is that the verdict you were shown in 2026 was built on exactly the evidence we said it was, and that we have not quietly rewritten the story since. Checking it does not require trusting us.

8 · WHAT IT COSTS TO RUN, AND TO GROW

52 ASEAN companies covered today, from a verified research basket	391 dated, sourced pieces of evidence behind the verdicts	\$0.079 AI cost per company per year — measured, not estimated	\$4.12 per year to cover all 52 companies	\$159 per year at 2,000 companies — the same method, region-wide
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The reason it is that cheap: the AI only *reads*. The scoring is ordinary software that costs effectively nothing to run, however many companies you point it at. The real expense is people — someone verifying each company's financial and green-bond details by hand — and the one figure we do not yet have is a licence quote for bulk baseline data. **So we do not draw the falling cost-per-company curve an investor expects to see.** On the costs we have actually measured, that line is flat. Drawing it before the number exists would be deciding the conclusion first, which is exactly what this tool exists to catch other people doing.

9 · WHAT WE ARE HONEST ABOUT

- Four companies clear our top "hidden winner" bar — and the bar never moved to let them in.** We published, in advance, the one reason that would justify changing it; then we gathered better sources, and four names crossed on their own. It is four and not forty because roughly 86% of what a public search returns is written by the companies themselves, and we cap how much that can ever count. The honest route to a longer list is better sources, not a smaller number — lowering our own bar until the screen returns the answer we wanted is precisely the failure this tool exists to catch.
- The basket we build on has an inconvenient second half, and we show it.** It returned 55.1% against the index's 6.4% over the study period — and lagged that same index by 4.6% year-to-date, with ESG improvement alone a weak predictor of any single share price. Both numbers always appear together.
- Some of our company data is marked provisional until a second person has reviewed it,** and it says so on screen. Verified by us is not an endorsement anyone else has given.
- Three of the best-known rating houses are missing by law, not by oversight.** Their scores are licensed products that cannot be displayed or redistributed without a contract. We use the one major provider that publishes a free, per-company score, properly attributed.

In one line: a rating tells you a level and asks to be believed. This tells you where it disagrees, on which dated evidence, what the company's own results say alongside it, what would change the answer — and leaves a receipt, so years later you can check we are not telling a different story than we told at the time.